When we finally reached her, she said the tiara would require an orderly and a police escort to leave the Palace.

That sounded…a bit much. But all right, I said, if that's protocol, let's find an orderly and a police officer and get the ball rolling. Time was running out.

Inexplicably, she replied: *Can't be done.*

*Why can't it?*

Her schedule was too busy.

She was being obstructive, obviously, but for what reason? We couldn't even hazard a guess. I considered going to Granny, but that would probably mean sparking an all-out confrontation, and I wasn't quite sure with whom Granny would side.

Also, to my mind, Angela was a troublemaker, and I didn't need her as an enemy.

Above all, *she was still in possession of that tiara.*

She held all the cards.

## 44.

THOUGH THE PRESS WAS mostly laying off Meg, mostly staying focused on the approaching wedding, the harm was already done. After eighteen months of trashing her, they'd riled up all the trolls, who were now crawling out of their cellars and lairs. Ever since we'd acknowledged that we were a couple, we'd been flooded with racist taunts and death threats on social media. (*See ya later, race traitor!*) But now the official threat level, used by Palace security to allocate personnel and guns, had reached vertiginous heights. In pre-wedding conversations with police we learned that we'd become *the* prized target for terrorists and extremists. I remembered General Dannatt saying I was a bullet magnet, that anyone standing next to me would be unsafe. Well, I was a bullet magnet again, but standing next to me would be the person I loved most in the world.

There's been some reporting about the Palace deciding to instruct Meg in guerrilla warfare, and survival tactics, in the event of a kidnapping attempt. A